

Federal court blocks Texas districts

Ruling that the GOP’s map employed racial gerrymandering is a blow to Trump’s plans.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — A federal court on Tuesday blocked Texas from moving forward with its new congressional map, hastily drawn in hopes of netting up to five additional Republican seats and securing the U.S. House for the GOP in next year’s midterm elections.

The ruling is a major political blow to the Trump administration, which set off a redistricting arms race throughout the country earlier this year by encouraging Texas lawmakers to redraw the state’s congressional district boundaries mid-decade — an extraordinary move bucking traditional practice.

The three-judge federal court panel in El Paso said in a 2-1 decision that “substantial evidence shows that Texas racially gerrymandered the 2025 Map,” ordering the state to revert to the maps it had drawn in 2021.

Texas’ Republican governor, Greg Abbott, who at Trump’s behest directed GOP state lawmakers to proceed with the plan, [See Redistricting, A7]



ABUSE survivors make a plea Tuesday outside the Capitol before Congress voted to demand the files’ release.

GRAEME SLOAN Bloomberg

BILL ON EPSTEIN RECORDS GOES TO TRUMP

President has signaled he will sign measure after reversing stance on the files’ release.

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — The long-standing fight to demand the Justice Department release all documents tied to its investigation into late convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein shifted to President Trump on Tuesday after the House and Senate, within hours of each other, voted overwhelmingly to publicize the files.

Trump, who tried to thwart the release of the records for several months, reversed course Sunday night and indicated that he plans to sign the measure when it reaches his desk. For that to happen, the Senate and House needed to approve the measure — and on Tuesday that happened with near-unanimous support in both chambers, at the urging of Epstein survivors.

The action, however, did not come without some tension.

Hours before the House vote, Speaker Mike Johnson (R-La.) said he would support the measure even though he believed it did not do enough to protect the privacy of the victims. Calling the bill “flawed,” Johnson then called on Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-S.D.) to fix the bill in the upper chamber before sending it to the president’s desk.

But amending the bill would have further delayed passage of the measure, prolonging a hugely divisive congressional fight. The Senate ultimately decided to quickly pass the bill without making any changes — or a recorded vote — after a successful procedural maneuver led by Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer (D-N.Y.).

“Epstein victim groups have made clear that they support this bill as written, without amendments,” Schumer said. “We should listen to them and pass this bill quickly.”

The House vote was 427 to 1, with Rep. Clay Higgins (R-La.) the only nay vote.

The votes were the culmination of a months-long fight that began when House Democrats, joined by a small group of Republicans, forced a vote on the transparency bill over the objection of Trump and Republican legislative leaders.

The effort underscored how the Epstein saga and the Trump administration’s handling of the files were fueling a rift within Trump’s political base, which in the end was strong enough to force top Republicans to cave.

In an emotional speech on the House floor, Rep. Marjorie Taylor Greene, a [See Epstein, A7]

Trump administration escalates effort to dissolve Education Dept.

Key programs move to other agencies. Vital services may be disrupted, critics say.

By HOWARD BLUME AND COLLIN BINKLEY

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration on Tuesday accelerated the dismantling of the U.S. Department of Education with a plan to transfer key, legally required functions to other

agencies, including oversight of its \$18-billion, core anti-poverty program, Title 1.

Critics said the move was politicized and counterproductive and fear future program cuts. California Supt. of Public Instruction Tony Thurmond said vital services to the state and nation’s most vulnerable students were likely to be disrupted.

The steps move toward fulfilling a Trump campaign promise to eliminate the department, which some conservatives have long derided

as wasteful, ineffective and unnecessary.

“The Trump Administration is taking bold action to break up the federal education bureaucracy and return education to the states,” U.S. Secretary of Education Linda McMahon said in a statement. “Cutting through layers of red tape in Washington is one essential piece of our final mission.”

President Trump called for the department’s elimination in a March executive order. Both he and McMahon have spoken of a broad

goal of sparking innovation through local control.

Even before this effort, states provided about 90% of their own funding for education, but federal investment is still crucial, advocates say. In particular, the federal role has focused on ensuring services are provided for overlooked students and students with higher needs, such as those facing discrimination and poverty, and students with disabilities.

While slashing the Edu- [See Education, A11]

Court rejects FTC claim that Meta holds monopoly

Ruling finds the firm’s purchase of Instagram and WhatsApp did not prove otherwise.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE AND WENDY LEE

WASHINGTON — A federal judge rejected the government’s antitrust suit against Meta Platforms Inc. on Tuesday, ruling that the company’s acquisitions of Instagram and WhatsApp did not give it monopoly control in social media.

U.S. District Judge James Boasberg in Washington, D.C., said the five-year legal battle showed that the social media market was ever changing, not static.

He said the Federal Trade Commission failed to prove that the tech giant had used its wealth and power to extend its control of the social networking market.

“With apps surging and

receding, chasing one craze and moving on from others, and adding new features with each passing year, the FTC has understandably struggled to fix the boundaries of Meta’s product market,” the judge wrote in an 89-page opinion. “Whether or not Meta enjoyed monopoly power in the past, though, the agency must show that it continues to hold such power now.”

The antitrust suit was first filed in 2020 during the first Trump administration. Back then, Boasberg said, the suits “did not even mention the word ‘Tik Tok.’ Today, that app holds center stage as Meta’s fiercest rival.”

He concluded, “Meta holds no monopoly in the relevant market.”

The decision is a major setback for the federal government and its antitrust regulators.

Biden administration appointees at the FTC had revived and pressed the suit [See Meta, A10]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

A HOME in Malibu’s Sunset Mesa is being rebuilt with fire-resistant material.

‘Herd immunity’ against fire? A concrete strategy

Homes made of composite block can shield others

By JACK FLEMMING

Sunset Mesa, the scenic neighborhood tucked on a bluff between Malibu and Pacific Palisades, might never be the same in the wake of the Palisades fire.

But resident Karen Martinez sees one potential change as a good thing.

The January fire torched about 80% of the community’s 500 homes — almost all of them wood-framed. Now, as residents begin the long process of rebuilding, Martinez is pushing her neighbors to chuck the lum-

ber and build with noncombustible materials instead.

The goal? The housing equivalent of herd immunity, where enough homes are fireproof that the entire community can be protected against future fires. Your home is far safer if your next-door neighbors’ houses aren’t burning down and sending fiery debris and showers of embers into the air.

The benefits of [See Fireproof, A8]

O.C. memorial is ‘a disgrace’

Fraud led to shoddy work on Vietnam War project, official says, in vowing to rebuild.

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

It was announced with great fanfare and hope: a memorial in the center of Orange County to honor veterans of the Vietnam War.

But two years and more than \$1 million later, the me-

morial stands as an unlikely symbol of corruption and broken promises.

The memorial project is plagued by shoddy construction and, according to Orange County Supt. Janet Nguyen, mired in fraud.

Standing in front of the memorial, which has already begun to show signs of cracking, Nguyen said last week that the structure should be torn down and a new memorial built to honor Vietnam veterans.

“It is shameful. It is a disgrace,” Nguyen said during a

Nov. 10 news conference at the memorial in Fountain Valley’s Mile Square Park. “We’re going to replace it. We gotta do it right because we owe it to these veterans.”

Aspirations for the project were initially high, with supporters saying it would be reminiscent of the memorial in the nation’s capital.

But its construction is rooted in scandal.

Former Orange County Supervisor Andrew Do was sentenced to five years in federal prison in June after [See Memorial, A8]

Roblox to verify ages with selfies

Popular gaming platform has been under scrutiny for child safety concerns. **BUSINESS, A9**

From Broadway to San Diego

La Jolla Playhouse finds next artistic director in the bold Jessica Stone. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Cool with some sun. L.A. Basin: 65/50. **B6**

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ANDREW CABALLERO-REYNOLDS AFP/Getty Images

SAUDI ROYAL’S VISIT

President Trump denies that Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman approved the 2018 killing of U.S. journalist Jamal Khashoggi. **NATION, A6**